

Conditioned norms: impermanence and the fate of Wikipedia's authority in the era of language models

Abstract

Wikipedia, once barred from classroom citation, is now invoked as a safeguard against machine-generated falsehood, even as its readership falls and the licence under which firms train models on its text says nothing about return. The essay treats this reversal as a case of how norms depend on conditions. It argues that Wikipedia's authority rests on a complex of credibility, contribution and reciprocity norms whose function is to make testimony accountable: traceable to its sources, open to challenge, and answered for by a community. Because these norms are conventional, they depend on circumstances, several of which have shifted. Some norms appear to be lapsing, some are being rewritten by the community, and for AI developers a reciprocity norm may never have formed. The sense of betrayal voiced by contributors registers unmet expectations, not by itself a broken commitment. Sorting the grounds on which reusers might owe something by their dependence on a cooperative scheme, the essay finds that fair play, cooperative beneficence and Humean convention bind only where such a scheme exists, that Kantian gratitude, the best-fitting unconditional ground, asks little and extends to firms only contestably, and that what is owed is a weak reason whose force depends on whether a scheme can be built. Buddhist impermanence serves as an interpretive resonance. The task is to hold the function and release the form; the most specific proposal is that the record of dispute behind Wikipedia's claims should travel with them into the systems that reuse its text.

Keywords: Wikipedia; large language models; social norms; convention; impermanence; accountability

1. Introduction

In 2007 the history department at Middlebury College voted to bar its students from citing Wikipedia, after a historian traced near-identical errors in a set of examinations to Wikipedia entries (Jaschik, 2007; Waters, 2007). Two years earlier a *Nature* exercise had found that the encyclopedia's science entries were not much less accurate than Britannica's (Giles, 2005). Students were already using it (Head & Eisenberg, 2010).

In 2025 the Wikimedia Foundation published a statement titled "In the AI era, Wikipedia has never been more valuable", asking the makers of language models to credit the human contributors and to pay for access (Wikimedia Foundation, 2025b). Its own analysis reports that almost all large language models train on Wikipedia datasets, and that human readership fell by roughly 8%, a fall it attributes in part to search engines and chatbots that answer directly, often from Wikipedia's own content (Miller, 2025). A source once scorned is now relied on, and is losing readers to the systems that rely on it.

It is tempting to tell this as a story of decline or of betrayal. This essay treats it as a case of how norms depend on conditions. Wikipedia's authority, its model of contribution and its expectations of those who use it are social norms that held for about two decades under particular circumstances, several of

which have shifted. The essay asks what follows for the standing of those norms, for what reusers of Wikipedia owe, and for what is worth keeping.

Its argument has four steps. Wikipedia's norms serve a function, which is to make testimony accountable: traceable to its sources, open to challenge, and answered for by a community (Sections 2 and 3). Because the norms are conventional they depend on conditions, and some of those conditions have changed, so that norms are lapsing in some places, being rewritten in others, and in the case of AI developers may never have formed (Sections 4 and 5). The strongest grounds for thinking reusers owe something are conditional on a cooperative scheme, which is why the question of what they owe turns on whether such a scheme exists and can be built (Section 6). The practical task is then to hold the function and release the form, and the most specific proposal is that the record of dispute behind Wikipedia's claims should travel with them into the systems that reuse its text (Section 7). The Buddhist idea of impermanence supplies an interpretive resonance for the second step and is used with the limits stated in Section 6.5; nothing in the argument rests on it.

The essay does not claim that Wikipedia is failing, that reuse of it is unlawful, or that the harm of reuse is large. The argument is conceptual and rests on public documents and the scholarly literature. Empirical premises carry their dates and sources, and the text says where the evidence is thin or comes from an interested party. The focus is the English-language edition.

2. Wikipedia as a conditioned complex of norms

2.1 Norms, conventions and reasons

The essay uses three terms in distinct senses. A *convention*, on Lewis's analysis, is an arbitrary, self-perpetuating solution to a recurring coordination problem, sustained because "no one has reason to deviate from it, given that others conform" (Rescorla, 2024, section 3.2). A *social norm*, on Bicchieri's account as summarised in the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, is a behavioural rule that people follow because of conditional preferences: they prefer to conform "conditional on 'empirical expectations' (i.e., first-order beliefs that a certain behavior will be followed) as well as 'normative expectations' (i.e., second-order beliefs that a certain behavior ought to be followed)" (Bicchieri et al., 2023, sections 1 and 5). A *reason*, here, is a consideration that counts in favour of acting; the question is when shared expectations generate one. The entry offers a bridge: on one account norms "function to hold us accountable to each other for adherence to the principles that they cover" (section 1). Where people hold normative expectations of one another, non-conformity is open to legitimate demand, and that gives each a reason to conform which does not depend on the sanctions that might follow. Strawson's account of reactive attitudes points the same way: resentment imposes on the other "a demand for moral respect and due regard" (Talbert, 2024, section 2.2).

Two consequences matter. A norm persists only while the expectations that support it are mutually held, so it can lapse without anyone changing their values, when expectations about others shift: "having conditional preferences means that one may follow a norm in the presence of the relevant expectations, but disregard it in its absence" (Bicchieri et al., 2023, section 5). And the change is typically not smooth: "there are long periods of no change punctuated by occasional bursts of activity in which an old norm is rapidly displaced by a new one" (Young, 2015, p. 363).

2.2 *Three strands*

Wikipedia's authority rests on three strands of norms, each with a history.

Credibility. The policy asks editors to base articles on "reliable, independent, published sources with a reputation for fact-checking and accuracy", and says that content "is determined by published information rather than editors' beliefs, experiences, or previously unpublished ideas" (Wikipedia contributors, n.d.). What it promises is provenance, that a reader can check where a statement came from, and not truth. When Middlebury barred citation, the historian who proposed the rule reported that a Foundation representative agreed, since Wikipedia is, like a print encyclopedia, a tertiary source (Waters, 2007). The standing of the encyclopedia has moved with the set of alternatives. Fallis (2008) defended it comparatively, as comparable in accuracy to traditional encyclopedias and better than other free sources. Credibility is a three-place relation, a source credible for some purpose relative to the alternatives open to the reader, so a change in the alternatives changes the standing of the source without any change in the source. Craig's (1990) account of knowledge makes the point generally: the concept serves "to flag reliable informants" (Ichikawa & Steup, 2026, section 9), so what counts as a good informant is a social standard answering to a social need, and it shifts when the available informants do.

Contribution. Wikipedia is written by volunteers, mostly pseudonymous or anonymous, under a licence that grants a "worldwide, royalty-free, non-sublicensable, non-exclusive, irrevocable" right to reproduce and share (Creative Commons, 2013, section 2(a)(1)). The norm is that the work is given, and the Foundation's terms say that the licences "do allow commercial uses of your contributions, as long as such uses are compliant with the terms of the respective licenses" (Wikimedia Foundation, 2023). In experiments with Wikipedia contributors, reciprocity and social image were strong motives for sustaining cooperation and altruism was not (Algan et al., 2016, abstract-level reading), which suggests that contribution rested on norms of return and recognition and not on pure gift.

Reciprocity in use. The third strand concerns readers and reusers: that people come to the site, that those who copy credit the source, that those who benefit do not hollow it out. The Foundation states it as the hope of "a virtuous cycle that continues those human contributions that create the training data that these new technologies rely on" (Wikimedia Foundation, 2025b). The licence supplies an attribution duty that applies when material is shared (Creative Commons, 2013, section 3(a)(1)), and a share-alike condition that applies "if You Share Adapted Material You produce" (section 3(b)); whether a model or its outputs count as adapted material is not settled by the sources reviewed here. The rest was expectation.

2.3 *Norms that revise themselves*

The norms were never static. Governance in Wikipedia has been described as "less akin to rule imposition by external authority than to constant reform and refinement of social norms within the community" (Forte & Bruckman, 2008, p. 2), and the anti-bureaucratic norm "Ignore all rules", sixteen words long, had within a year generated a page of over 500 words that changed over a hundred times (Butler et al., 2008, p. 1101). Halfaker et al. (2013) report that active English editors peaked at 56,400 in March 2007, and trace the decline to quality-control machinery, including tools that reject contributions, which treats good-faith newcomers badly, and to norm-articulation mechanisms that

calcified against changes proposed by newer editors. The machinery that made the practice reliable thinned the community that carried it.

2.4 Conditions of arising

On the early Buddhist formula of dependent arising, "when this exists, that comes to be; with the arising of this, that arises. When this does not exist, that does not come to be; with the cessation of this, that ceases", and the point is that "things are dependent on specific conditions" (Vélez de Cea, n.d., section 3.f). A parallel runs through Western conventionalism. Hume held that "it is only from the selfishness and confined generosity of men, along with the scanty provision nature has made for his wants, that justice derives its origin" (book III, part II, section II), and that the convention in question "is not of the nature of a promise" but "only a general sense of common interest; which sense all the members of the society express to one another" (section II) (Hume, 1739-1740/2003). Rawls builds on this: the circumstances of justice are "the normal conditions under which human cooperation is both possible and necessary", and "unless these circumstances existed there would be no occasion for the virtue of justice" (Rawls, 1999, pp. 109-110). Norms of cooperation exist where conditions make them useful, and the question for any norm is which conditions held it up.

Four can be named for Wikipedia's norm-complex. They are the essay's reconstruction and not an established causal history, and they differ in how well the sources support them. First, a path from reader to editor, which the Foundation's own call to "elevate opportunities to visit and participate in those sources" (Miller, 2025) presupposes. Second, a cost of reuse high enough that those who copied also credited and visited, for which the infrastructure and traffic evidence of Section 4 is the nearest support. Third, a licence culture in which giving freely was met by a shared expectation of acknowledgement, for which the experiments on reciprocity in Section 2.2 give partial support among contributors. Fourth, scarcity of trusted free reference, so that Wikipedia stood well in the relevant comparison, which is an inference since the sources cited do not measure scarcity. The first two have direct support, the third partial support.

3. The function: accountable testimony

If the complex is conditioned, the question is what it is for. The proposal is that it makes testimony accountable. Three properties describe what the community provides. They are a working vocabulary for this essay and not terms from the literature: *provenance* (a claim points to a published source), *contestability* (any claim can be challenged through a recorded process), and *answerability* (a community with rules answers for what stands). Together they make a claim accountable in the sense that a reader can trace it, challenge it, and know who answers for it. The word *auditability* might suggest an auditor independent of the audited, and no such party exists here: the editors who check are part of the community that answers.

Accountability is not a rival to truth. It is valued in the way social epistemology values practices generally, by their tendency to promote true belief (Goldman, 1999), and it serves truth-tracking in two ways: it lets errors be found and corrected, and it lets readers calibrate how far to trust a claim. Hardwig (1985) argued that where no individual has all the evidence one may have to accept "knowledge that is known by the community, not by any individual knower" (p. 349). Most readers

cannot check most claims, and Wikipedia compiles sources and does not produce the knowledge in them. The checking is divided: editors check the link from claim to source, the fields that produced the source answer for its content, and the reader can verify that a source exists, sample the check, and see whether a claim has been disputed. What the reader gets is not a full check but the assurance that a check is possible and has been attempted by people who answer for it. Menking and Rosenberg (2021), drawing on Code's epistemic responsibility and Longino's procedural objectivity, argue that the project's pillars privilege the product over the process, and that authority can assert itself through accuracy and reliability "precisely because authority can always be questioned" (p. 469). Magnus (2009) notes that quality varies and the reader must judge where Wikipedia is likely to be reliable; provenance and a record of dispute are the cues that judgement needs. Whether the answerable party is the individual editors or the community as a source of group testimony (Tollefsen, 2009) is left open.

Systems that retrieve and cite sources now offer a link from claim to source, so provenance in the narrow sense no longer separates Wikipedia from a generated answer. Whether the cited sources support the claims they accompany is an empirical question this essay does not settle. What a citation link does not carry are the other two properties, the record of dispute and a community with rules that answers for the result (Section 7.1).

4. The conditions change

4.1 The licence is silent

The licence says nothing about training a model and nothing about returning anything to the source. The steward of the licences reads their reach narrowly: "AI training is often permitted by copyright", so that "the CC license conditions have limited application to machine reuse" (Pearson, 2025). Courts have not filled the gap. *Doe v. GitHub* concerned code under open-source licences, not Wikipedia text: the Ninth Circuit affirmed dismissal of a Digital Millennium Copyright Act claim on the theory that Copilot's outputs remove copyright management information, treated the training-stage theory as forfeited, and left two contract claims pending (*Doe v. GitHub, Inc.*, 2026). Lemley and Casey (2021) argue that training should generally be fair use, in which case licence conditions are not reached at all. Nothing found here establishes that reuse of Wikipedia text breaches its licence, and the essay does not assume it does. The gap is not a violation: it is the point at which the third strand of norms, which the licence never fully encoded, was left to expectation alone.

4.2 Reuse at scale, and the readers who no longer arrive

Much of the evidence in this subsection comes from the Foundation, which is an interested party, and is marked as such. Models draw on Wikipedia's text: the Foundation says almost all large language models train on its datasets (Miller, 2025), though its share is small in volume, since Wikipedia and Wikibooks together, in English and Simple editions, are about 0.14% of the tokens in one open corpus, and Wikipedia is 4.5% of the sampling mixture in another (Soldaini et al., 2024; Touvron et al., 2023). Any reliance is on curation and quality and not on bulk, and whether it can be replaced is contested (Shumailov et al., 2024; Gerstgrasser et al., 2024).

Two kinds of cost must be kept apart. The first falls on infrastructure. At least 65% of the most resource-consuming traffic to the Foundation's data centres comes from bots, which account for about 35% of pageviews, and bandwidth used for multimedia has grown by 50% since January 2024, "largely" from scrapers feeding images to AI models (Mueller et al., 2025); not all bot traffic is linked to AI developers. Wikimedia Enterprise, the paid-access service, earned 4.0% of Foundation revenue in fiscal 2024-25 (Wikimedia Foundation, 2025a), and in January 2026 named further partners without terms (Wikimedia Enterprise, 2026). The second falls on the path from reader to editor. The Foundation reports human pageviews down roughly 8% against 2024 and attributes this to search engines "providing answers directly to searchers, often based on Wikipedia content" (Miller, 2025). The academic evidence is mixed: in twelve editions through early 2024 views and visitors did not fall and rose less where ChatGPT was available, while edits and editor numbers showed no fall (Reeves et al., 2025), against larger declines in editing and viewing for new, popular articles overlapping with ChatGPT's output (Lyu et al., 2025). The first cost is the better evidenced. Whether the second erodes the supply of editors is not established.

4.3 Two other norm-complexes

The comparison with Stack Overflow and Reddit shows that complexes of this kind change in different ways. Stack Overflow lost its contributors: monthly new questions that are still visible fell from 207,171 in March 2014 to 5,262 in October 2025 (author's retrieval from the Stack Exchange data interface, October 2026), and activity fell by 25% within six months of ChatGPT's release relative to comparison forums, which the authors treat as a lower bound (del Rio-Chanona et al., 2024). Its owner announced a partnership under which OpenAI would "provide attribution to the Stack Overflow community within ChatGPT" (Stack Overflow, 2024). Reddit did not shrink: its 2025 revenue was \$2.2 billion, up 69% (Reddit, Inc., 2026a, 2026b). Wikipedia lost a modest share of attention, with falls of 6.7% and 7.9% in English-language views in 2025 and 2026 (retrieval from the public pageviews interface, October 2026), while keeping its scale and its finances. A loss of norms need not be a loss of the institution, and the reverse.

4.4 The community rewrites its own norms

The community has responded. It has run a cleanup project against machine-generated text, adopted a narrow speedy-deletion criterion, and in March 2026 voted 44 to 2 to prohibit LLM-generated or rewritten article content (Bansal, 2026; Froneman, 2026). In interviews with 16 editors who had used language models, Zhou et al. (2026) report that newcomers used the tools to fill gaps in knowledge, that fitting the output to community norms took tacit knowledge they lacked, and that other editors accepted such edits from experienced editors and called out and rejected them from newcomers. Open-source projects are doing the same (Hora & Robbes, 2026, a preprint read at abstract level). Communities are writing down norms that were once tacit because a cheaper form of contribution has broken the assumptions behind them.

5. Lapse, non-formation and resentment

5.1 Resentment without breach

The reaction to this reuse is often called betrayal. Holton (1994) locates the difference between trust and mere reliance in a participant stance, a readiness to feel betrayal if reliance fails, as against the objective stance in which another's failure produces annoyance and not resentment. Hawley (2014) puts commitment at the centre of betrayal. To trust is to believe that someone has a commitment and to rely on them to meet it; commitments may be implicit, since "mutual expectation and convention give rise to commitment unless we take steps to disown these". But expecting what nobody committed to produces a feeling and not a fact: "we may feel betrayed, but we have not been betrayed".

Hawley's implicit-commitment sentence bears directly on the case and cuts both ways. If an open-knowledge convention existed among those who reuse Wikipedia, commitments could have arisen from it unless reusers took steps to disown them. Whether the convention existed among developers, and whether any disowned it, is not shown by the sources reviewed here. The norm account explains how the feeling can arise without a breach. While the expectations of the third strand were mutually held, a contributor had reason to expect acknowledgement and a visit in return. Where reuse at scale no longer needs the visit, the empirical expectation fails first, and the normative expectation may persist as a sense that it ought to hold. The result is resentment, which reports the expectation. Real commitments run to platforms and not to editors, as in the Stack Overflow partnership above.

5.2 Lapse and non-formation

The language of lapse presupposes that those who now fail to reciprocate once held the norm. For readers and small reusers that is plausible. For AI developers it is not shown: they may never have belonged to the reference network within which the reciprocity norm held, a network of contributors, readers and the downstream users of an era when copying was by hand. If so, what is happening with developers is not the lapse of a norm they held but the failure of a norm to extend to a new population, and the task is not to restore an old expectation but to form a new one. The distinction matters for what can fairly be demanded. A demand grounded in a lapsed shared norm appeals to what the party already accepts; a demand grounded in a norm that never extended must offer reasons for joining.

5.3 What editors think

What editors themselves think of this reuse has not been measured systematically, and the argument does not assume an answer. The nearest evidence is indirect. In expert interviews one participant reported that the objection heard most often from Wikipedians is that "the situation doesn't seem fundamentally fair", since editors work unpaid under an open licence while large firms profit (Vetter et al., 2025); this is a second-hand report from six experts and not an account from editors. A survey of editors on the future of the project was being prepared by volunteer researchers and had no results (Gelauff, 2026). A norm in the course of lapsing would be expected to look so, with some members still holding the expectation and feeling its breach and others already past it.

5.4 Tacit norms become explicit, and who can re-institute them

Norms that were tacit while conditions held are written down once they are threatened: the Foundation's requests for credit and for access through its paid service (Wikimedia Foundation, 2025b), Creative Commons' signals, described as "a flexible, commons-friendly framework for communicating expectations around AI use of content or data" and not called binding (Creative

Commons, n.d.), and the contribution policies above. Longpre et al. (2024) document the other response, in which data holders without a channel for stating terms close their data: a growth of crawl restrictions in 2023-24. Writing a norm down turns a shared expectation into a request and a request into a candidate rule. Bicchieri and Mercier (2014) note that it may take only a small number of trendsetters who question the standing norm and start behaving differently to effect a major change. Centola et al. (2018) found in experiments that a committed minority could overturn a convention once it reached about a quarter of the group, in a setting that models conventions and not sanction-backed norms. These accounts suggest that a norm of credit, route back and carried provenance among reusers would need a critical mass of them, which points to collective arrangements among reusers and not to single adopters.

5.5 What would count against this account

An account that explains any outcome explains none, so the claims here should be exposed to failure. If the lapse reading of resentment is right, resentment should be stronger among those with stronger prior expectations of acknowledgement, such as long-standing contributors who valued recognition, and not simply among those most affected by lost readership; a survey finding the opposite would count against it. If the reciprocity norm extends to reusers once made explicit, requests for credit and route back should be followed by growing adoption among reusers, and a flat or falling rate would count against it. If codification marks lapse and not routine maintenance, new written norms should cluster where pressure is greatest, as the AI-contribution policies do. If non-formation is right, developers' policies should show no prior commitment to acknowledging open sources. None of these is tested here.

6. Conditional reasons

6.1 Reasons that depend on a scheme

If norms of cooperation arise under particular circumstances, then the obligations that go with them depend on the existence of a cooperative scheme. That is the structure of Hume's conventionalism, on which Rawls builds in his account of the circumstances of justice, though Rawls is a constructivist and not a conventionalist: duties of justice arise where cooperation is possible and needed, and there would be no occasion for them otherwise (Rawls, 1999, pp. 109-110). It is also the structure of the best-supported accounts of why those who draw on a practice might owe it something. The question for reuse of Wikipedia is therefore two-part: what do the best accounts say is owed within a scheme, and is there a scheme that includes reusers?

6.2 Classifying the grounds by their conditionality

The grounds in moral and political philosophy that bear on the question can be sorted by how far they depend on a scheme.

Grounds that do not depend on a scheme. Rawls's natural duty of justice "requires us to support and to comply with just institutions that exist and apply to us", and "also constrains us to further just arrangements not yet established, at least when this can be done without too much cost to ourselves";

because it presupposes no voluntary act, "they apply unconditionally" (Rawls, 1999, p. 99). It concerns just institutions in a full political sense, so applying it to a voluntary association is an extension by analogy, and Simmons's particularity objection asks why one institution and not another (as reported in Dagger & Lefkowitz, 2021, section 4.4). Singer (1972) holds that "if it is in our power to prevent something bad from happening, without thereby sacrificing anything of comparable moral importance, we ought, morally, to do it". These turn on need or harm, and the harm found in Section 4.2 is mild.

Kant's duties of beneficence and gratitude fit the case better. To deal kindly with those in distress "without hoping for anything in return" is, he writes, "a mutual duty incumbent on us all" (Kant, 1796/1886, Sec. 30), an imperfect duty that leaves latitude about form (Johnson & Cureton, 2022, section 5). Of gratitude he holds that it is "a sacred duty", one whose obligation "can never be adequately acquitted and discharged", since "the benefactor [has] always the good desert of being first in the benevolence"; that it "goes back to our ancestors, even to those whom we cannot certainly name"; that its intensity depends on the advantage derived and "the disinterestedness which prompted the benefactor"; and that its least degree is, when the benefactor is no more, "to show like services to others" (Sec. 32-34). Volunteers who give anonymously under a licence that asks nothing are about as disinterested as benefactors come, and the extension to those one cannot name matches the case. Three difficulties remain. The duty is owed by persons, so its application to firms runs through the people who build and decide. Most philosophers hold that gratitude requires a benefactor who acts intentionally under the description of benefiting the recipient (Manela, 2019, section 2), and contributors who wrote for readers in general did not write for developers in particular. And Kant adds a warning that bears on gifts of this kind: no kindness is truly shown "when I thrust upon him a present without his will" (Sec. 31), which echoes Nozick's objection below. Gratitude is the unconditional ground that fits best, with a modest content, goodwill and at least like services to others, and a contested extension.

Grounds that depend on a scheme. Hart (1955, p. 185) held that when persons conduct a joint enterprise according to rules and restrict their liberty, "those who have submitted to these restrictions when required have a right to a similar submission from those who have benefited by their submission", and Rawls (1964) made it a duty of fair play. Rawls's later statement requires that the institution be just and that one "has voluntarily accepted the benefits of the arrangement or taken advantage of the opportunities it offers to further one's interests" (Rawls, 1999, p. 96). Nozick objected that the principle "as we stated it following Hart and Rawls, is objectionable and unacceptable": neighbours who run a public address system cannot oblige you to take your turn merely because you have benefited, and at the very least the benefits to you must exceed the cost of your share (Nozick, 1974, pp. 93-94). Developers meet that minimal condition, since the cost of credit and a route back is small against the benefit, and they chose the benefit. Simmons (1979) replies that obligations arise only where benefits are accepted and recognised as others' cooperative product, and Klosko (1992) asks that the goods be presumptively beneficial, later "indispensable for satisfactory lives" (both as reported in Dagger & Lefkowitz, 2021, section 4.2). A cooperative account of beneficence, on which each agent owes a fair share of what is needed to meet a problem given that others do their share (Murphy, 2000; Cullity, 2004), likewise depends on a scheme in which others are contributing. And Hume's convention is the scheme itself. It binds the parties to a mutual forbearance, so a reuser who gives nothing back stands outside it, which is why the question is whether reusers can be brought

inside by explicit terms. Hume's scarcity condition fits the practice and not the text: the labour and attention that sustain Wikipedia are scarce even though copies of its text are not.

No ground. A gift to anyone, under an irrevocable royalty-free licence, creates no claim for individuals, whatever Mauss (1925/2024) says of reciprocity in general, and a labour-desert or rights view that held contributors to deserve credit whatever the licence would face the fact that they gave under a licence of their own choosing. A public-benefit view adds that language models may do good that outweighs any claim of the contributors. The first of these is right that editors are not owed payment or credit as a debt for past gifts, and the essay makes no such claim; and exploitation, which can be mutually beneficial and consensual yet unfair (Zwolinski et al., 2022), would need a theory of fair division that the essay does not supply.

6.3 What is owed, if anything

The result is a classification and not a derivation. The unconditional grounds of need and justice do not clearly apply, because the harm is mild and the institution is not a political one; Kantian gratitude applies with a modest content and a contested extension to firms. The conditional grounds apply where a scheme exists. They share a premise: those who knowingly benefit from a practice that others sustain, and can help at small cost, have a reason not to leave its upkeep to others. That is the content of fair play, and the essay does not claim to have escaped it; it is also close to the least that gratitude asks, to show like services to others. What differs is its standing. The reason is conditional on a scheme whose existence depends on shared expectations, it is stronger where the practice is fairer to those who join it and where use burdens the infrastructure, as scraping does (Section 4.2), and it is weak where, as Section 5.2 suggests for AI developers, the scheme has not formed. The reason concerns a practice from which readers, reusers and editors all benefit, and the essay leaves open whether any party could press it; on Hart's formulation the right would belong to those who submitted to the restrictions, which would make editors, collectively, the right-holders, and the essay does not claim that. Two goods are in play: Wikipedia's text is non-rival, since copying does not diminish it; the practice that produces the text is rival, kept going by labour and by newcomers who arrive. The reason concerns the second good, which is why it is compatible with free use of the first.

The step to an epistemic commons is this essay's own; the nearest work is Hess and Ostrom's (2007) point that shared resources survive through community rules and not licences alone, Viljoen's (2020) argument that the value and harms of data are supra-individual and call for collective governance, Benkler and Nissenbaum's (2006) view of commons-based peer production as a setting for character formation, and Huang and Siddarth's (2023) proposal that developers contribute quality data back to the commons they draw on.

6.4 The role of the scheme: building it

A conditional reason does not by itself require building the scheme on which it depends. The case for building one rests instead on Section 3: if the function of accountable testimony is worth keeping, and keeping it depends on reuse that carries the record and supports the practice, then those who benefit have a further reason to take part in making such an arrangement, and the conditional reason of Section 6.3 would then apply to them within it. The forms are those already met: credit and a route back, which is cheap and, if readers follow the link, helps recruitment as well as traffic, as the Foundation's call to

"elevate opportunities to visit and participate in those sources" assumes (Miller, 2025); paid structured access, which the Foundation caps at 30% of its annual revenue to protect independence while saying the content "will forever be free and open to anyone" (Becker, 2026), though its terms are not public; and preference signals. A pooled arrangement run by the commons' own governance, with published terms, would answer the problem that reliance varies across thousands of reusers, and proposals for multi-party governance of language data offer a template (Jernite et al., 2022). Given Section 6.3, these are requests and not demands.

6.5 The Buddhist resonance, and its limits

The idea of impermanence is used here as an interpretive resonance, not as a source of premises. In early Buddhist thought whatever is conditioned is impermanent: "whatever becomes, that is conditioned, volitionally formed, dependently arisen, that is impermanent" (Vélez de Cea, n.d., section 3.d). The two errors the tradition names, eternalism and annihilationism, are defined in terms of essences: "the doctrine that all things exist because of an eternal essence" and "the doctrine that things have essences while they exist but that these essences are annihilated just when the things themselves go out of existence" (Hayes, 2023, introduction). The mapping to Section 6.2 is therefore loose: the grounds that do not depend on a scheme resemble the first only in being independent of conditions. The second has a closer textual match. In the *Sāmaññaphala Sutta* Ajita's doctrine, that "there is no meaning in giving, sacrifice, or offerings" and "no fruit or result of good and bad deeds", is called "the doctrine of annihilationism" (Sujato, n.d.-d, 23.2, 24.1), which is near the denial that acts toward a commons carry ethical weight, though the view that nothing is owed for a free gift is weaker than Ajita's. The tradition also prizes the grateful: "these two individuals are rare in the world", the one "who takes the initiative, and one who is grateful and thankful" (Sujato, n.d.-e, 2.119). What the resonance contributes is the structure of the middle position. The early texts supply closer instances than the later philosophy. The *Aggañña Sutta* tells a story with the structure of Hume's. When the self-renewing rice no longer regrows, the beings agree to "divide up the rice and lay down boundaries"; when one takes another's share, they gather and elect one among them "who would rightly accuse those who deserve it, blame those who deserve it, and expel those who deserve it", to be paid "with a share of rice"; the office is called "elected by the populace" (*mahāsammatā*), and its authority rests "by virtue of principle, not against principle" (Sujato, n.d.-a, 18.27-21.4). An institution arises by agreement in response to changed conditions and is judged by a principle beyond the agreement. Two passages bear on the revision of norms and on function over form. In the *Mahāparinibbāna Sutta* the Buddha says that "if it wishes, after my passing the Saṅgha may abolish the lesser and minor training rules" (Sujato, n.d.-b, 6.3.1), and in the *Alagaddūpama Sutta* he teaches "a simile of the teaching as a raft: for crossing over, not for holding on" (Sujato, n.d.-c, 13.1). The step to conventional reason rests on the norm account of Section 2.1, and the criterion by which a norm is improved, that it serves the function that gave it point, is the essay's own, drawn from Craig and Hardwig. No source was found that applies impermanence to institutions or technology, so the application is the essay's. Hume's conventionalism could carry the argument alone, and the resonance is retained because the conditions and passing of norms are the subject of the essay and the tradition has long made them the subject of its own.

7. What the function requires

If the norms are conditioned, the practical question is which part to hold. The function is accountable testimony. The form includes the institutional centrality of one encyclopedia, particular rules, and the habits of one era of the web. The recommendations below follow from locating the function in accountability and from the conditions of Section 2.4, and they do not depend on whether reusers contribute. They are the essay's own, drawn from the literature, and each is limited by how much of that literature the essay has reviewed. Only the community and its stewards can decide them.

7.1 *Let the dispute record travel*

What models take is the text, which is the output of the practice. They do not take the properties that make the practice accountable. Provenance travels in the text's references, but the record of dispute and the community that answers for the result stay behind. The Foundation's paid service already carries part of the trail. Its data dictionary lists parsed references and, for each revision, the editor's name, the edit comment and three machine-generated credibility signals, a revert risk, a reference risk and a reference need; for the previous version it gives only an identifier and a character count, and it lists no field for talk-page discussion or dispute history (Wikimedia Enterprise, n.d.). What travels is therefore provenance and a measure of how risky an edit looks, and not the contest itself. Revision histories and talk pages are already public on the site, so the proposal concerns what travels in structured feeds and reuse products, not disclosure. The recommendation is that Wikipedia extend what travels to the record of contest, meaning the discussion, reverts and protection history behind a claim, and ask reusers to carry it, so that a reader of a generated answer can follow a claim back to its source and to the dispute about it. This answers the first condition of Section 2.4, the path from reader to editor, since a reader who sees the dispute can enter it. Talk pages can expose volunteers, so what travels should use aggregated or pseudonymous records, and a feed for retrieval-based systems is easier to build than one for training.

7.2 *Protect the way in*

The practice is carried by people, and its binding constraint is who can join, which is the same condition. Experiments give a mixed picture. In a controlled trial on the English edition in 2014-15, newcomers sent an invitation to the Teahouse, a place to ask questions, delivered by a bot and signed by a named host, were more than 10% more likely than the control group to be editing three to four weeks after registering and to have made five or more edits two to six months later (Morgan & Halfaker, 2018); the analysis counts invitation and not participation, and its authors treat the result as conservative. A newcomer homepage combining suggested tasks, a mentor module and help links, tested in 2021 on 27 non-English editions, slightly raised early activation but had no significant effect on two-week retention, on productivity or on revert rates (Warncke-Wang et al., 2023). The two differ in design, edition and period, so the contrast is suggestive only. The defence against machine-generated text raises the risk of the old pattern, since tools for rejecting contributions applied at scale reject good-faith newcomers with the bad (Halfaker et al., 2013; Zhou et al., 2026). The recommendation is that the community measure and publish newcomer survival alongside its measures of machine-generated text, and test pairing rejection with a personal, named explanation and invitation, with the added volunteer labour counted as a cost.

7.3 Release what should lapse, and widen without loosening

Some of the form deserves to lapse. The same rules that give the practice its legitimacy produce its gaps. Tripodi (2023), using 38 months of deletion data on 22,174 biographies, finds women consistently over 25% of the biographies nominated for deletion while they were under 19% of all biographies, and reads the higher rate at which such nominations were kept as evidence of mistaken nomination, an inference open to challenge. Ford and Wajcman (2017) argue that the expertise required to take part is coded as male, and Gallert and van der Velden (2014) describe a catch-22 for oral knowledge: the reliable-sources rule excludes oral transmission, and keepers of knowledge are judged too close to their subjects. Fricker's (2007) framework of testimonial and hermeneutical injustice names how some knowers are discounted; this essay does not apply it. Ostrom's design principles add that most individuals affected by a resource regime should be authorised to participate in making and modifying its rules (Ostrom, 2010, design principle 3). The recommendation is that the community publish how notability and deletion decisions fall across categories of subject, so that the disparity Tripodi infers can be tested, and develop documented procedures through which community-held knowledge may enter, designed with the communities that hold it, so that widening is done by procedure and not by lowering the standard of checking. These changes bear on the function itself, since a practice that excludes knowers cannot be contested by them. Smaller editions, where the practice is thinner, raise the stakes: the Vietnamese edition's share of culturally specific content was 2.5% in a 2018 comparison of 40 editions, the third lowest (Miquel-Ribé & Laniado, 2018), and a lower-bound remeasurement in October 2026 gave 1.8% against 9.7% to 19.7% for 13 other editions.

7.4 Open the books, and plan for succession

The argument asks reusers for transparency and asks the same of the steward. The Foundation announced partners for its paid service without giving terms (Wikimedia Enterprise, 2026). The recommendation is that it publish the terms of reuse agreements, or the principles that govern them, and an account of how income from reuse is divided between infrastructure and the support of participation.

If institutions are conditioned, the function should be able to outlive any one of them. Answerability is a property of a community, so holding the function means preserving the practices and records through which a community can be held to account, whichever community that is. The text can persist under an irrevocable licence; the record of discussion and dispute is the part most at risk, and archiving it in portable form lets the function survive a change of institution. Section 7.1 is therefore also succession planning. None of the proposals predicts its own success.

8. Objections and conclusion

The lens is decoration. The resonance is marked as such, and Hume's conventionalism could carry the argument alone. The Buddhist material is retained for the structure of the middle position and for the attention to conditions, and nothing in Sections 2 to 7 rests on it.

The account explains everything. Section 5.5 sets out what would count against it.

Conventional reasons are too weak for a philosophy of obligation. They are weak, and this essay says so. Where expectations are firmly held, as in an explicit partnership, a conventional reason is strong, and the weakness here follows the thinness of the expectations in question.

AI will absorb the function regardless. It may. The essay's test is functional, so absorption would count as success if what is absorbed includes provenance, contestability and answerability; the claim of Section 7.1 is that today it does not include the record of dispute.

AI answers may serve readers better, so who is wronged? No one need be. The claim concerns the standing of norms and the function they served. Systems that cite sources already offer a link from claim to source, and where their citations are accurate that serves readers well. What a link does not carry is the record of dispute and an answerable community.

A light reason is too lenient. A reason of this kind is not the only route. Regulation, contract terms, public funding of the commons and collective control over data are others that this essay does not assess. Search engines stand in a similar position to developers, and the reason extends to them in proportion (McMahon et al., 2017).

Wikipedia's authority was a conditioned complex of credibility, contribution and reciprocity norms whose function is to make testimony accountable. Several of the conditions have changed, and the norms are lapsing among some, being rewritten by the community, and may never have formed among the new class of reusers. The sense of betrayal registers the expectations that those norms had made reasonable, without by itself showing a broken commitment. The strongest grounds for thinking reusers owe something depend on a cooperative scheme, so the question of what they owe becomes the question of whether such a scheme can be built, and the reason that remains is weak and conditional. What is worth holding is the function, and what is worth releasing includes parts of the form. The most specific thing the argument supports is that the record of dispute behind Wikipedia's claims should be able to travel with them.

Three limits should be kept in view. No study yet measures systematically whether editors hold an expectation of return from AI developers (Section 5.3 gives the indirect evidence), whether readers sent to a model fare worse than readers sent to the source, or how far the sources that Wikipedia cites are being contaminated by machine-generated text. The philosophical sources are used largely through encyclopedia entries and abstracts, and the application of impermanence to norms is the essay's own. And the empirical premises about reuse and its costs come largely from the Foundation.

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